Event Lead Engine: GTM Case Write-up

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I built an engine that finds leads at live events, scores them and queues them for a person to approve. It has pulled, scored and queued 311 leads (49 tier A, 133 tier B, 115 tier C, 14 tier X) from 10 public events across Germany, the UK and the US. Nothing goes out on its own. A reviewer approves each lead before any enrichment or CRM step runs. This keeps spend down and keeps contact inside each market's rules.

I built it as a hands-on GTM case for a B2B software company. The buyer profile used here is an example: accounts that run SAP or Dynamics, and the AP and procurement people who handle exceptions. The engine is not tied to one company. Section 9 shows what changes for a new one.

1. What I built

Layer	Details
Database	Supabase (Postgres), hosted in the EU. The public key can only read masked views. Full data comes back only through functions that check a reviewer passcode.
Cockpit	A single-page app with four tabs: review queue, events, health and metrics, how it works. Names, companies and contact data stay hidden until a reviewer unlocks it.
Orchestration	n8n runs four workflows: sourcing, enrichment, a dead-letter queue for errors and a feedback receiver for bounces and replies.
Finding events	A Python script against the Serper API, Firecrawl for pages that only render through a script, and LLM research for early pooling.
Enrichment	Apollo for company lookups, Clay for the email waterfall, Hunter for SMTP verification. Clay also supports Cognism and Datagma as fallbacks. I have not used either.
Drafting	An LLM agent (Clay's Claygent) writes the opener from a structured prompt. The output must pass a schema check before it reaches the CRM.
CRM	HubSpot batch upserts keyed on our own lead and account IDs, so a re-run never creates duplicates. Still a dry run: nothing has written to a live CRM.
LinkedIn	A Sales Navigator link on each card for manual lookup. Not automated, because scraping risks a ban.
Outbound	Smartlead or Instantly for sending. Not live yet. The workflow that reads bounces and replies is built and waiting for the first send.

2. Finding the events

I scored each candidate event on a 50-point rubric, and ten passed. I pooled candidates from LLM research and a Python script against the Serper API, removed duplicates by URL, then scored each one on five factors from 0 to 5: buyer density (x3), ICP match (x3), ease of getting lead data (x2), timing (x1) and cost (x1).

Two rules shaped the result. First, only speaker, sponsor and exhibitor pages that organisers publish are read. Two high-scoring events were dropped because their sites block automated readers or load speaker lists through an API that robots.txt disallows. I did not bypass either. Second, an event hosted by a competitor is not rejected. Its leads are capped at tier B, because the audience is real but weaker.

Event	Market	Leads	Event	Market	Leads
BME-Symposium Einkauf und Logistik	DE	69	IOFM Fall Conference & Expo	US	21
UKISUG Connect (read with Firecrawl)	UK	61	FATE	US	15
Manifest	US	55	Einkaufsforum Mittelstand	DE	10
NRF 2027	US	35	CFO Summit London	UK	10
Handelsblatt CPO-Summit	DE	26	Radiance 2027 (competitor-hosted, tier B cap)	US	9

One event's page still lists the previous edition's speakers, so those leads need a refresh before use. Next, the plan is to add signals that do not need an event: ERP migrations, procurement and AP hiring spikes, leadership changes and technology footprint.

3. Qualifying leads and spending credits

One failing cue ends the check, so a strong signal cannot be averaged away by weak ones. A weighted score would let a big company name outvote a missing buyer function. So each lead goes through a fast-and-frugal tree, a decision method

where the first failing cue decides the outcome. Each card in the cockpit shows the path it took, so a reviewer can overrule it.

Cue	Outcome if it fails or applies
Does the person work in a buyer function?	No: dropped
Does the person work for a vendor?	Yes: dropped
Is the person below manager level?	Yes: tier C
Does the title own the invoice, payment, order or purchasing process?	Yes: tier A, as the champion
Is it a senior person, with a second named buyer at the same event?	Yes: tier A, as the economic buyer
Everything else	Tier B or C

Company-level fit, such as size and industry, is checked after approval by the company lookup, so credits are only spent on leads a person has already accepted. How much gets spent depends on the tier:

Tier	Credit level	Spend
A	3 (2 if a hiring signal is found)	Company lookup plus a hiring scan, capped at 15 credits per account
B	4	One basic company lookup
C and X	5	Nothing. No credits spent.

4. Reaching the right people

A deal that runs through one contact usually dies. Most of these accounts have six to ten people in a purchase decision, so the cockpit tracks which of three roles it has covered at each account. The aim is to round out the committee with up to two more contacts once an account has an approved lead.

Role	Worried about	Lead with
Champion (AP or operations)	Exceptions they handle by hand	A one-page business case written for IT
Economic buyer (CFO or CPO)	Cost and risk of changing anything	A no-upfront-cost pitch and a free pilot
Technical evaluator (IT)	One more project in the backlog	Integration specs and a sandbox with 30 to 50 real cases

One rule: context, not data. A customer discovery call shaped the messaging above, including the objections, the persona language and which signal gets priority. Nothing from that call, including the person and their company, went into the database.

5. Making it reliable

The system is built so a failure is visible, retried safely and never reaches a customer. Five choices carry this:

- **Review cockpit.** It follows situation-awareness research: see what matters, understand it, see what comes next, without piecing it together across tabs. Keyboard shortcuts keep review fast (j and k to move, o to open the source, Shift+A to approve, Shift+R to reject). Approve needs Shift, so a stray key cannot start enrichment. The benchmark for this pattern is a review-time cut of over 60%. I have not measured that at this volume.
- **Drafting.** The opener and research note are templates for now. An LLM step plugs into the same place, and its output has to pass a schema check before it reaches the CRM.
- **A gap I found and closed.** The masked database views still carried default insert and update rights, which would have let the public key write around the review gate. I removed them and moved every write behind functions that check a token. The public key now reads only masked views.
- **Safe retries.** Two workflow runs can never claim the same lead, because rows are claimed with a lock that skips rows already taken. Failed steps go to a dead-letter queue that a worker retries automatically, using the lead's own key so a retry never duplicates. After five failed attempts it waits for a person.
- **Pre-mortem.** Before launch I assumed the system had failed badly six months in and worked backward. That surfaced an expiring trial, an organiser changing a page layout and unhandled rate limits. Each got a fix ahead of time. Monthly reviews will trace a bad outcome back to the system and the workload, not to whoever clicked approve.

6. Staying inside the law in each market

Compliance is built into the data and the workflow, not added as a checklist. This is how I designed it, and it is not legal advice. Outreach is not live, so none of the notices below have been sent yet.

Market	Rule built in
US	A clear opt-out, a physical address in every email, and suppression that takes effect at once (CAN-SPAM).
UK and EU	Legitimate interest is the basis, assessed before any data is collected. The CJEU confirmed in C-621/22 that a commercial interest can count, if it is necessary and the person's rights do not outweigh it. Each contact carries a source tag, which is used to build the Article 14 notice, and a one-click opt-out stops everything. The UK check also covers PECR and TPS.
Germany	No cold email (UWG section 7(2)). First contact is a LinkedIn note from a person. Cold calling is blocked until a reviewer logs a specific reason. In BVerwG 6 C 3.23 (29 January 2025), the court held that public business phone numbers cannot be stored for phone advertising on legitimate interest alone, without at least a presumed consent.

The same care applies to the cockpit itself. Without the reviewer passcode, the public view shows initials and a role level only. Names, companies and contact data appear after unlock. Contact emails are never shown in the cockpit at all.

7. Syncing to the CRM

The CRM sync is still a dry run: payloads are built and checked end to end, but nothing has written to a live CRM.

- Contacts match on our own lead ID, set when the lead is first ingested. Companies match on a normalised name key. Neither depends on having an email address, so matching never breaks.
- Every sync searches before it creates. It never overwrites a field a person edited, respects whoever already owns the account, and checks the opt-out list in both directions.
- The feedback workflow is built and waiting. Once sending starts, replies and bounces flow through n8n into the database and feed a view that proposes changes to the scoring tree. A person applies them. It has been tested with fake events only.

8. Proof it runs, and what does not yet

Two real leads ran through the whole pipeline, one on each path:

- **German path.** The call gate for UWG section 7 applied, a tier-A credit level was assigned, and a dry-run CRM payload completed in under six seconds.
- **UK and US path.** Clay's waterfall found a work email, Hunter verified it by SMTP, and it was saved without the address showing in the cockpit.

What is not live: sending, writes to a live CRM, reply and bounce data, and meetings booked per event. The paid add-ons (Apollo people match and Cognism) are planned and need paid access. The cockpit's health tab shows these as "not live yet", so the numbers on screen match what this write-up claims.

9. Pointing it at another company

For a new company I change the buyer profile and the event list, not the engine. The example profile here is AP and procurement teams on SAP or Dynamics. Another company would get its own.

Part	Stays the same	Changes per company
Event scoring	The 50-point rubric and its weights	The buyer profile that buyer density and ICP match are judged against
Qualification tree	Its shape: cues, named exits, tier mapping	Which functions count as buyers, which titles own the process, which vendors to drop
Credit spend	Spend by tier, with a cap	The cap and the paid providers
Buying committee	Three roles per account	Role names, worries and what to lead with
Compliance	Rules built in per market	The markets the company sells into
Cockpit and CRM sync	Review flow, masking, retries	Field mapping to their CRM

For a company I really want to work with, I would run five to ten of its real events through the same scoring and show the result.

10. A note on GenAI tools

I used GenAI, Claude in particular, throughout this project: to debug n8n workflows and prompts, to speed up event research and to draft and tighten this write-up. The architecture, the scoring logic, the event research and every decision behind them are mine. AI made the execution faster. It did not make the calls.